

Episode 159: Long Ago... 97 1995 Part 17 Storm of Colour Samples and Copic is Divine! November and December

Everyone! Have you finished your tax returns? This year's tax return is due March 14th! Last year I thought "ah, next year I'll ask a tax accountant!" but ultimately this year was also self-calculated & document preparation. "Ah, next year for sure..." Well, but I'll probably do it myself next year too... (distant look).

...Actually, at the time I'm writing this manuscript, I haven't finished this year's tax return yet (explosion). The plan was for it to be properly finished by the time this manuscript appears - should be, should be, should be? (sweat)

Now, will it happen!?

Anyway.

Season progresses from autumn to late autumn. *Neighbourhood Story* production proceeded almost smoothly. About weekly art & colour direction meetings were scheduled, and character colour checking progressed at roughly the same pace.

Character setting work procedure: for main character settings, we'd make costume change bases from basic design character settings drawn by Umakoshi-san, then Costume Designer Kawamura-san would draw costume changes on top of those base settings like "dress-up dolls."

Main appearing characters were seven people: Mikako, Tsutomu, Jiro, Yusuke, Risa, P-chan, and Mariko. Characters would increase further in the latter half, but these costume changes happened every episode. About 7 outfits appeared each episode at one per person. Well, after accumulating episodes, clothing would accumulate and some reuse became possible, but this series also followed seasons somewhat, so summer clothes, winter clothes... Since it was a year-long story, each character had considerable clothing.

For main characters, guest character and prop settings appearing in each episode were principally drawn by each episode's animation director. Combined with earlier main settings, we created quite a number of colour settings each episode.

Making colour samples from those character settings - all colour samples were cel paintings. Cel paint colouring. Even starting to use Mac, we were still far from current digital colouring levels of painting settings on screen and making colour samples. Having all those colour samples painted with cel paint and finished into cels myself would be quite time-consuming, so we had company finishing staff paint them. But first, I myself needed proper colour images.

In previous works, I'd carefully paint setting copies with multiple coloured pencils to create my own images, but that was forced mental conversion. When thinking mentally, quite specific cel paint number colour images already exist in my head, but naturally, cel paint and coloured pencils are completely different. No matter how much I convinced myself with paint numbers, it only became division instruction samples when making cel colour samples. Moreover, that itself took considerable time - couldn't I create images closer to finished painting? That had been a long-standing concern.

Then I noticed certain colour marker pens at an art supply store. A series called "Copic." Trying them out (trial colouring), these were very good. Being alcohol markers, they could be painted quickly and uniformly, and above all, had good colour development. So I bought almost all available colours at light speed (laugh). Boom! Set them up at both work room and studio. Come to think of it, these Cotics were also at Yazawa-sensei's workplace.

Using colour copy paper, I'd place colouring conceived mentally onto black and white copied character line art using these Cotics. Why use colour copy paper? Because colour copy paper had much better ink adherence and finished colour development than ordinary copy paper. Painting with Cotics that developed colours close to cel paint numbers I was thinking of meant finished Copic settings had quite similar atmosphere to

cel images. Then I'd specify colours again with paint numbers and have finishing staff paint colour sample cels.

Using Copics, I gradually wanted colours "between this colour and that colour, like paint number ○○" - colours other than manufactured ones. So I'd blend and mix supplementary inks myself, creating and using new original colour Copics (laugh). Gradually becoming a maniac (laugh).

That much - this method of thinking character colours using Copics was revolutionary for me. Mac was also new weaponry, but this was immediate combat power! Anyway, since I could reproduce colour images conceived with colouring quite close to cel finishing, not just character colour samples, but for complex pattern still colour direction, I could paint divisions and place colours myself using this, confirming my own images while making finished images and detailed divisions easier to convey when requesting cel trial painting.

While handling *Neighbourhood Story* character setting colour work daily like this, another work was actually operating in parallel behind the scenes. Such was autumn 1995.

(11.03.08)